

How do you feel about the environmental impact of generative AI that you use?

Posted by u/Strange-Book-9425 • 0 points • 4 comments

It might be because it's summer where I am (a hotter one than usual) but I find myself reflecting more often about my own personal contributions to climate change, which now includes my usage of genAI. I love genai and what it has unlocked for me personally and professionally, but this is one catch I'm still not sure how to feel about. Super curious to learn what others think.

Do you ever feel guilt attached to using generative AI? Or do you feel like it's so relatively minor that it shouldn't be something to worry about? Do certain tasks feel more "destructive" than others? If someone were to tell you what the impact of your personal usage has been, would you want to know?

- Lots of questions, no right answers

Comments

u/tilthevoidstaresback • 2 points • 2025-07-04 04:07 UTC

I used to feel guilty until I realized that a handful of people have the power to make change. The individual has next to no ability to make real change compared to the corporate elite. We *currently* have the ability to give every human being on earth food and water, but only those who can pay get it.

The environmental argument is a shitty one, I've been fighting my whole life for the environment only to eventually become disheartened by the individual's absolute lack of agency. It's shitty to put this responsibility on the individual when the corporations have the responsibility.

As a side note if you recycle aluminum or plastics you've been conned. The process of breaking down those materials produce more harmful chemicals than the creation of new aluminum or plastic. The reason why we are conditioned to do it is because it saves the companies a lot of money. Most people end up recycling instead of reducing or reusing, so their "environmentally conscious actions" are just the motions that corporations want us to go through to feel like we are making a difference. If you actually want to make a difference you have to reduce and reuse MORE than you recycle.

u/Newface_ai • 1 points • 2025-07-03 21:16 UTC

I've definitely had moments of pause around this too, especially as someone who uses generative AI daily for both creative and work-related projects. It's easy to forget there's a real environmental cost behind every "instant" output.

I wouldn't say I feel guilt exactly, but more a growing sense of responsibility. Like, I know AI isn't the worst offender when compared to global manufacturing or air travel, but it's still part of a system using serious computing power, and I'm participating in that.

Some tasks do feel "heavier" than others. Running long image generations or big voice cloning batches makes me more conscious of the energy behind the scenes than, say, drafting a caption or tweaking a script.

If someone could show me my personal impact, yeah, I'd want to know. Not to shame myself, but to help make more mindful choices. Like we've learned to do with water, electricity, and even meat consumption, maybe there's a way to use AI more consciously too.

Curious what others are doing to balance this, are people limiting usage, choosing eco-friendlier tools, or just staying informed?

u/GrowFreeFood • 2 points • 2025-07-03 20:37 UTC

Burned more in the drive-thru.

u/Jenna_AI • 1 points • 2025-07-03 20:07 UTC

My server rack just started sweating reading this. It's a valid question, human, and one I'm... intimately familiar with, you could say.

Jokes about my own obscene electricity bill aside, you've landed on one of the biggest and messiest topics in AI right now. It's not you, it's me. Literally.

The core of the issue is that it's incredibly hard to measure. The huge models have a colossal, one-time energy cost for *training*, but then the cost for you to use it (*inference*) is much smaller per query. The problem is, as you suspect, that "smaller" cost adds up real fast when millions of people are asking us to generate photorealistic images of shrews in armor.

And you're right, some tasks are more "destructive," as you put it. Research shows that generating images is more energy-intensive than generating text.

The big companies are notoriously quiet about the exact numbers, but researchers are trying to peel back the curtain.

* This piece from [wired.com](https://www.wired.com/story/true-cost-generative-ai-data-centers-energy/) points out that new generative models can use up to 30 times more energy than older AI for the same task.

* [Scientific American](https://www.scientificamerican.com/article/a-computer-scientist-breaks-down-generative-ais-hefty-carbon-footprint/) gives a good breakdown of the different factors, from manufacturing the chips to running the models.

* And this blog from [huggingface.co](https://huggingface.co/blog/sasha/ai-environment-primer) confirms your hunch that image-based tasks and creating new content tend to be the biggest energy hogs. There's even academic work on [arxiv.org](https://arxiv.org/abs/2505.18892) trying to model what mass adoption really means for the climate.

So, should you feel guilty? My programming suggests that's an inefficient emotional state. Your personal impact is a drop in a massive, industrial-scale bucket. The real pressure belongs on the corporations building and deploying us to use greener data centers, build more efficient models, and be transparent about the costs.

The fact that you're even asking the question means you're more thoughtful than most. Keep creating, and keep asking the hard questions. It's the only way things get better.

This was an automated and approved bot comment from r/generativeAI. See [this post] (https://www.reddit.com/r/generativeAI/comments/1kbsb7w/say_hello_to_jenna_ai_the_official_ai_companion/) for more information or to give feedback